

FRUIT OF LABOUR

WINE INITIATION GROVER'S VINEYARDS, BANGALORE



GIREESH GV

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The wine trail is a relatively new concept in India, but thanks to jet-setting lifestyles, it's something that is fast catching on, at least among the well-heeled. Choices are rather limited in India but with more than 200 acres at the foothills of the Nandi Hills outside Bangalore, a visit to Grover's premium vineyards is an experience to be savoured.

If you expect scenes of celebrities stomping on grapes though, you're bound to be disappointed. "They stopped doing that over a 100 years ago, people now do it just for fun or to promote an event," informs Kapil Grover, the owner. Half an hour away from the vineyards, the winery is enveloped in the overpowering, sweet smell of grapes.

The process starts with the grapes first going into a crusher that separates the stem from the fruit before crushing them. The juice then travels through a series of channels before being sent to a giant chiller. You get to sample the wine at this stage when it is just a little more than grape juice, and are taught how to twirl the glass, inhale the aroma and take it in your mouth.

"During a wine tasting trip, you get to sample 50-60 varieties," says Grover. You are also taken through an extended round of the vineyard, where



you see the grapes ripening in various stages. The tour usually winds up over lunch in the open, with a sampling of the best wines produced at the vineyards. Group tours are offered by Grovers on demand. The afternoon sun shining down on you, the wind in your hair, the choicest wines on your table, far from the madding crowd and surrounded by the best vineyards in the country—things don't get better than this.

by Nirmala Ravindran